

BEFORE

Genocide—the murder of a group of people, for their religion or race, for example—has long been part of human life. The Holocaust is the result of such a policy, but it was not the first genocide of the 20th century.

ANTI-SEMITISM IN EUROPE AND RUSSIA

Anti-Semitism has its roots in the Roman Empire when **early Christians attacked Jews**, blaming them for the death of Jesus Christ. During the Crusades of the 11th century << 200–01, Jews were expelled from many western European nations << 227. Numerous Jews died in **pogroms** (organized massacres) in Russia in the late 19th century.

ANTI-SEMITISM Discrimination, hostility, or prejudice directed at Jews as a religious, racial, or ethnic group, expressed in actions that can range from individual hatred to state-prosecuted persecution and violence.

ARMENIAN MASSACRE

In April 1915, the government of the Turkish Ottoman Empire accused the 1.75 million Armenians under its control of collaborating with the enemy, Russia. Over seven months, **600,000 Armenians were killed**. In addition **500,000 were deported** to what is now Iraq. Of these, only 90,000 survived. A further **400,000 Armenians lost their lives** when the Turks

invaded the Russian Caucasus in 1918. The **massacres continued until 1922**, when the remaining Armenians were driven from Turkey.



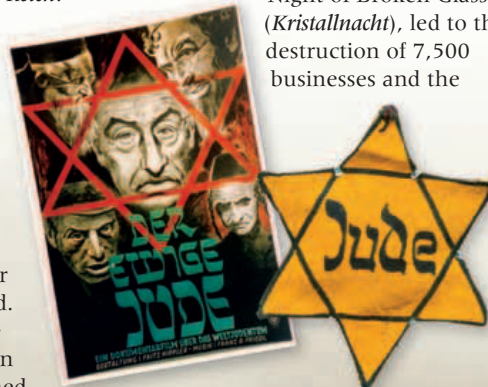
POSTER FOR ARMENIAN RELIEF

A central feature of the world view of the German dictator Adolf Hitler (see pp.390–91) was an alleged struggle between Germany, as the only state capable of rescuing European civilization, and an international Jewish conspiracy to subvert and dominate the world. He picked up these views from the popular anti-Semitism of the time, which saw Jews both as parasitical capitalists and as revolutionary Bolsheviks (see p.376). Either way, Hitler saw the Jews as an evil, implacable enemy of Germany who should be driven from the *Reich*.

The Nazis in power

Hitler took power in January 1933 and began a slow process of reducing the civil rights and economic position of the country's half-million Jews. They were removed from civil service and from many of the professions in 1933–4 and their shops and businesses boycotted. Thousands took refuge in exile abroad, and by 1939 fewer than half of Germany's Jews remained. In September 1935 the notorious Nuremberg Laws stripped Jews of their German citizenship and prohibited marriage or sexual relations between

German Jews and ethnic Germans, or “Aryans” (see pp.387). In 1936 a program was set in motion to strip Jews of their assets, and by the outbreak of war, most Jewish property had been taken by the state or bought at reduced prices, to be sold on to “Aryan” owners. It was not until November 1938 that the Jews were threatened with widespread violence. A pogrom, known as the “Night of Broken Glass” (*Kristallnacht*), led to the destruction of 7,500 businesses and the



Poster advertising “the Eternal Jew”

In the film made by Joseph Goebbels, Hitler's Minister of Propaganda, scenes of Polish Jews living in Warsaw were intercut with images of rats. The Star of David had to be worn by all Jews under Nazi control from 1941.



“Kristallnacht”

The shattered glass of the many Jewish properties that were attacked on November 9–10, 1938 gave the night its name.

death of 91 Jews. After this 8,000 Jews were expelled from Berlin and around 25,000 Jewish men sent for a short spell in German concentration camps, where they were subjected to a brutal regime of punishment and labor.

Jewish isolation

Initially, Hitler's goal was to exclude the Jews from Germany. The Nazis reached an agreement with the Zionist movement to speed up emigration to Palestine (see pp.414–15). But by 1939, as thousands more Jews came under German control in Austria and areas of Czechoslovakia, it proved difficult to get other countries to accept Jewish immigrants. At the Evian Conference

5-6 MILLION Jews were killed, including 3 million Polish Jews.
212 THOUSAND Roma and Sinti gypsies were also exterminated.
70 THOUSAND disabled people in Germany were killed.

The Holocaust

The word “Holocaust” comes from two Greek words: *holo*, “whole,” and *kaustos*, “to burn.” The term is most closely associated with the deliberate attempt to annihilate the Jewish race in Europe from 1941 to 1945, probably the most shocking and far-reaching act of the age.

Death factory

At Auschwitz-Birkenau, train tracks lead to the main guardhouse, which prisoners called the “gate of death.” From 1940, three labor and death camps were built here; more than 1 million Jews died here from 1941 to 1945, when the Soviet Red Army liberated the camps.

